

Where Is Ja?

How concerned should we be about Ja Morant's performance in 2025-26?

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Introduction

The 2025-26 NBA season was the end of an era for the Memphis Grizzlies. They traded Desmond Bane before the season, they traded Jaren Jackson Jr. to the Jazz near the deadline, and now they traded two-time All Star and the face of the franchise, Ja Morant. It was a difficult ending: Morant played only 79 games in the last three seasons, including missing the second half of Game 3 (a 29-point comeback by OKC) and the entirety of Game 4 in the First Round of 2025.

The 2025-26 Grizzlies languished on their way to a 25-57 record in which Morant played only 20 games; Memphis had a staggering 33 players suit up for them in 2025-26. When Morant played, it was alarming how inefficient he was:

G	W-L	MIN/G	FG%	3P%	FT%	AST	TOV	PTS
20	7-13	28.5	41.0%	23.5%	89.7%	8.1	3.6	19.5

Table 1: Ja's 2026 Season

Whether it was the constant injury absences or the dissolution of the Grizzlies' core, Morant struggled to get anything going in 2026. The discourse surrounding Morant has grown as pessimistic as it has ever been, but is the situation truly that dire? It was a 20-game season on a terrible team struggling with injuries to many key players. Not to mention, Morant constantly appeared in trade rumors in the last two seasons.

My goal here is to break down Morant's 2026 season and examine how significant the decline in his offensive game truly was. As a note, this paper strictly adheres to the basketball side of Morant's Grizzlies tenure. I argue that, given 2026's sample size and crumbling team around him, Morant's offensive decline has been overstated.

New Lows

Morant was never a strong perimeter shooter, but he shot career lows in nearly every shooting statistic:

Time frame	FG%	2P%	3P%	FT%	eFG%	TS%
2019-25	46.9%	51.9%	31.6%	76.6%	50.8%	55.9%
2026	41.0%	47.3%	23.5%	89.7%	44.1%	52.1%

Table 2: Morant's shooting woes in 2026

In every statistic except free throw percentage, Morant was well below his career averages in 2026. Given that he only played twenty games, he didn't qualify for any shooting percentage ranks, but how did his percentages rank compared to the rest of the league when the thresholds are adjusted?

Stat	Threshold	Rank	Stat+
$FG\%$	$FGM \geq 130$	273rd out of 299	87
$2P\%$	$2PM \geq 110$	219th out of 234	86
$3P\%$	$3PM \geq 20$	359th out of 364	65
$FT\%$	$FTM \geq 105$	9th out of 146	115
$eFG\%$	$FGM \geq 130$	Worst out of 299	81
$TS\%$	$TSA \geq 370$	251st out of 268	90

Table 3: Morant's shooting relative to the rest of the NBA

Besides free throw percentage, Morant had career lows in each of these shooting percentages, and he was among the worst in the league. The plus stat reflects Morant's standing compared to league average, where 100 is always average. For example, an 87 $FG+$ means that his field goal percentage was 13% below league average.

Stat+

$$S+ = 100 \times S_{player} / S_{league}, \text{ where } S \text{ is any statistic.}$$

Morant has never been a particularly strong jumpshooter. His career-high $3P+$ is 97 in 2021-22. However, his standing among all NBA players has never been so low. Morant's $eFG+$ and $TS+$ have always hovered around the 90-100 range, so his 2025-26 output was quite a regression (Figure 1)

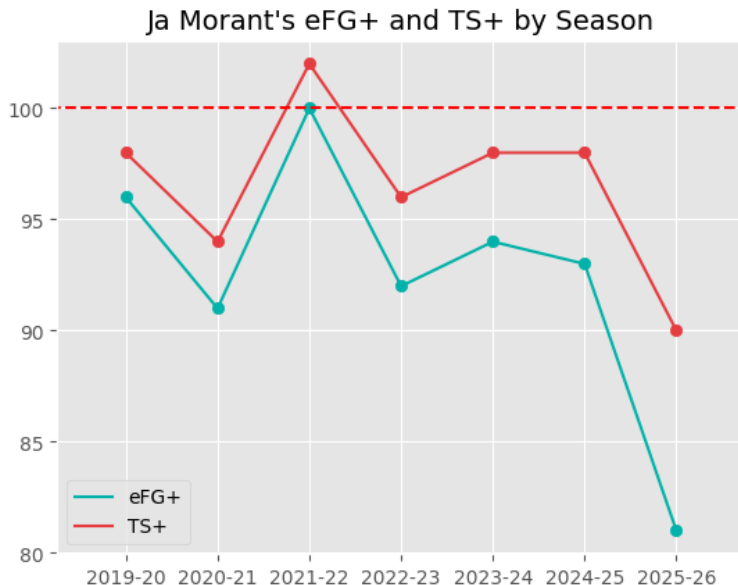


Figure 1: Morant's $eFG+$ and $TS+$ by Season

The importance of Morant's ability to knock down jump shots is debatable. On one hand, defenses being forced to respect his jumpshot causes his slashing to be even more dangerous. On the other hand, allowing Morant to gain a head of steam is dangerous,

too. His last All-Star season was 2022-23 and he had a below average $TS\%$ and $eFG\%$ (Figure 1). Ideally, Morant should pose an “okay” threat. He doesn’t need to shoot Anthony Edwards levels of three pointers, but he should be respectable, especially to maintain viability and efficiency given age or injuries.

Speaking of injuries, Morant and the core members of the 2025-26 Grizzlies were plagued by them. They experienced league-high levels of roster volatility (Table 6). Given the team-wide injury epidemic and the fact that Morant only played 20 games himself, a new conclusion emerges: His shooting might not be this bad. It was a small sample size compared to the rest of his career. Is there enough evidence to suggest that this was a significant difference. Visually, it certainly appears so, but what about statistically?

Test Design

Let θ_C represent a statistic from Morant’s career prior to 2026 season. Conversely, let θ_{26} represent a statistic from Morant’s 2025-26 season.

$$H_o : \theta_C - \theta_{26} = 0$$

$$H_a : \theta_C - \theta_{26} > 0$$

Test Results

Here are the test results with $B = 2000$ bootstrap replicants (Figure 2). The bootstrapping is done on the games themselves, rather than treating each individual shot attempt as its own event.

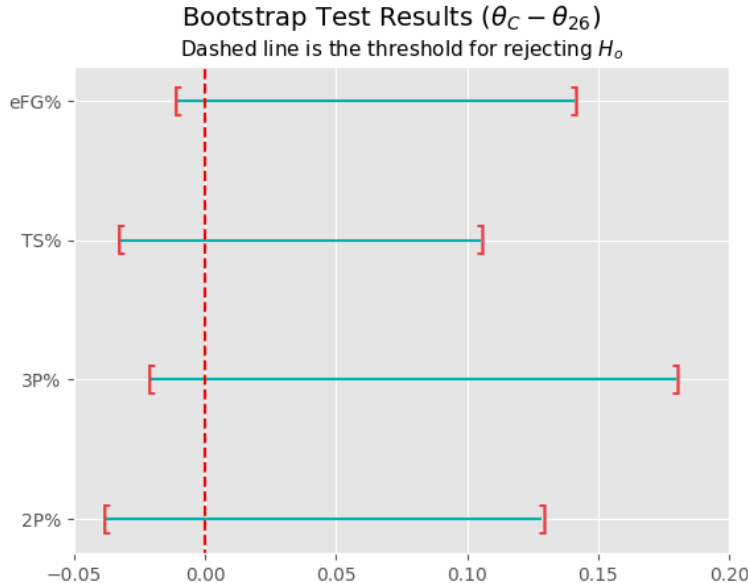


Figure 2: Bootstrap Results for Morant’s shooting percentages in 2025-26

All four intervals intersected with zero, meaning that we fail to reject H_o for all four of them. With 95% confidence, there is no evidence of a statistically significant difference in these four shooting percentages between Morant’s 2025-26 season and his career before (2019-25).

There is a noticeable caveat within that conclusion. All four intervals are centered in positive territory, especially those that are centered around three point shooting ($eFG\%$

and 3P%). H_a is not accepted, but it's very close. Morant's shooting percentages were very brutal across the season. However, given it was only 20 games, that's why the intervals turned out the way they did.

Morant's 20 games can be split into two halves, before and after his calf injury suffered on November 15, 2025. He played twelve games before that and eight games following his return, before being shut down for the season with his elbow injury. Here is a breakdown of his stats in the two stretches, excluding his game on Nov. 15 since he only played six minutes.

Stretch	G	MIN/G	PTS	AST	TOV	FG%/3P%/FT%
Before Nov. 15	11	30.8	18.9	8.1	4.0	.352/.167/.954
After	8	27.9	21.8	8.8	3.2	.488/.400/.833

Table 4: The sample size grows even smaller

That's a stark difference. Morant had two games before November 15 where he shot above 40% from the field (35 and 28 points) compared to five following his return. If Morant didn't injure his thumb, perhaps he would have continued this strong stretch of play and his season averages would have drowned out those nine difficult games of his¹. Every statistic excluding free throw percentage is better after his return from the calf injury. He scored more points and dished out more assists in less minutes. His shooting percentages skyrocketed and the more advanced shooting metrics reflected the same picture.

Stretch	eFG%	TS%	FTr	3PAr
Before Nov. 15	.378	.469	.337	.311
After	.528	.587	.378	.197
2019-25	.508	.559	.370	.246
All-Star Seasons (2021-23)	.517	.566	.381	.233

Table 5: Advanced shooting stats compared to his career entering 2025-26

Morant's FTr and $3PAr$ in the latter eight games reflect another positive: He was playing more like the Ja we're accustomed to seeing. Less threes and more free throw attempts are signs that Morant was more aggressive and possibly healthier. That was the main cause for alarm: It wasn't just that Morant was struggling, it was his offensive approach. It was his shot distribution. His metrics in the eight post-calf-injury games are more comparable to his career and All-Star level metrics.

I've already made my argument for how Morant can't be written up based on nine bad games, but I performed the same bootstrap analysis using Morant's All-Star campaigns for comparison instead of his entire preceding career.

Let θ_{AS} represent a statistic from Morant's two All-Star seasons: 2021-23.

$$H_o : \theta_{AS} - \theta_{26} = 0$$

$$H_a : \theta_{AS} - \theta_{26} > 0$$

All four intervals are closer to statistical significance than when compared to Morant's entire preceding career (Figure 2), but still not quite there. Again, the 20-game sample size combined with around half of them being high quality performances makes it difficult to conclude that it's a huge deal, both qualitatively and quantitatively.

¹The Grizzlies still might have shut him down or even traded him assuming they still were tanking.

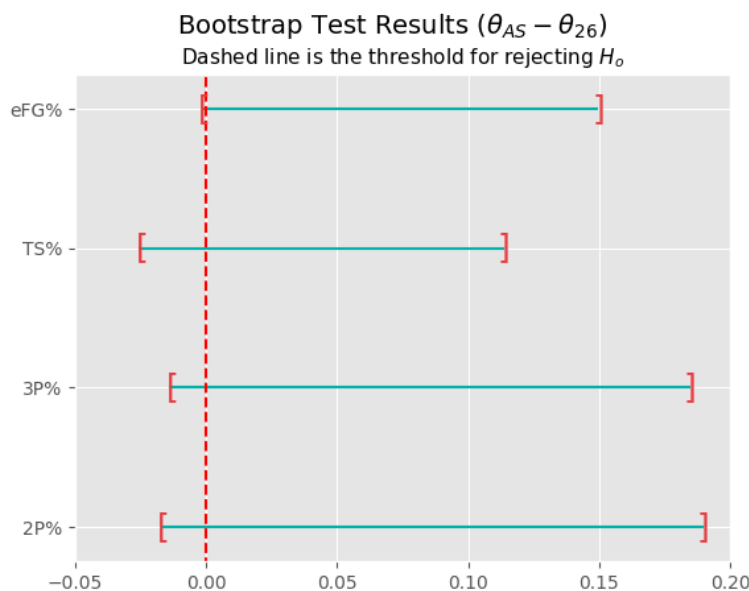


Figure 3: Bootstrap Results Compared to Morant's All-Star Seasons

Downhill

As I mentioned previously, the biggest cause for alarm in Ja Morant's game was not his efficiency; it was his shot selection. Morant is a relentless slasher who sacrifices his body attacking the basket. Four years removed from Morant's last All-Star season, there is concern that he is attacking less.

First, we have to acknowledge that Morant has been beat up since entering the NBA. His style of play possesses great longevity concerns, and Morant has never played 70 games in a season before (Figure 4).

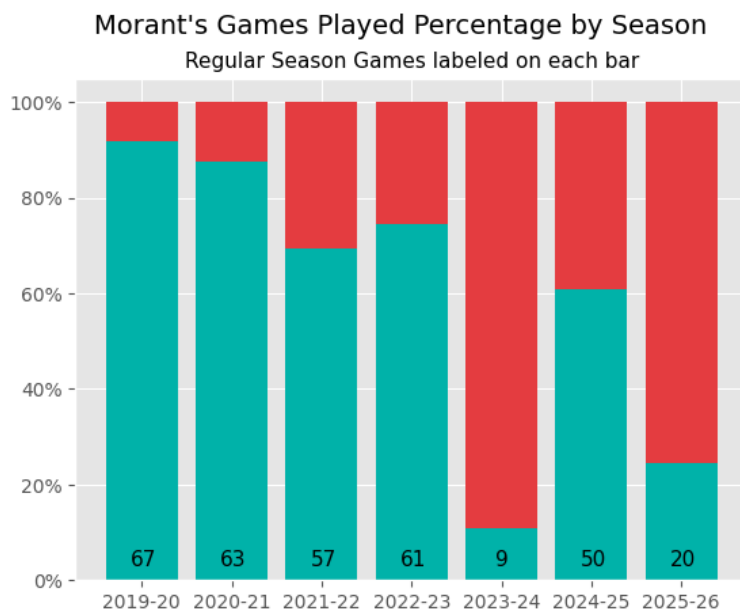


Figure 4: Morant's Possible Games Played by Season

Morant has played in less than 70% of the Grizzlies' regular season games in four of the last five years. This gives some truth to the concerns about Ja's offensive viability today. At 27 years old, Morant will certainly have to adjust his playstyle to stay on the court. Hopefully, that doesn't mean taking as many threes as we saw in the first half of 2025-26, but it does mean developing more of an inside-out game (Table 5).

Attacking the Rim

Given Morant's difficulty staying on the court, his rim attempt rate has dropped over the years:

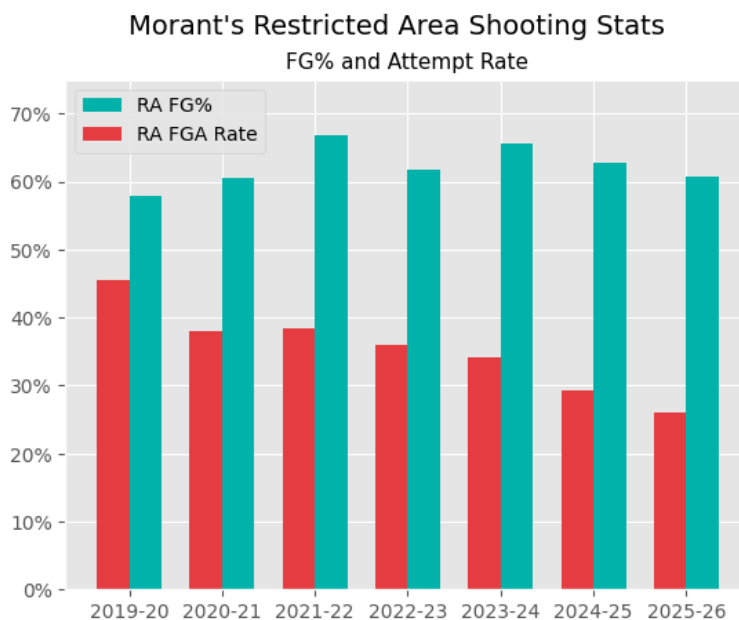


Figure 5: Morant's Restricted Area Shooting Profile

His attempt rate has declined from about 45% of his field goal attempts to below 30% today. There are more factors at play than just health: Defensive emphasis, his teammates, the evolution of his game, etc.

One thing to note is that his restricted area field goal percentage has never dipped from its usual level. Morant has shot around 60% from the restricted area in nearly every season of his career. For reference, here's how some of Ja's player comparisons² shot in the restricted area in their All-Star seasons (Figure 6).

Morant compares very favorably to some of the best athletic point guards of the 2010s in terms of scoring within the restricted area. His 2025-26 season is the one on the far left of the graph, indicating that his attempt rate dropped out of the normal range among these elite slashers. For Morant's standards, 2025-26 was abnormally low. I conducted the same bootstrap analysis using Morant's restricted area shooting stats this time.

²He was often compared to D-Rose, Russell Westbrook, and John Wall when he was a rookie/prospect.

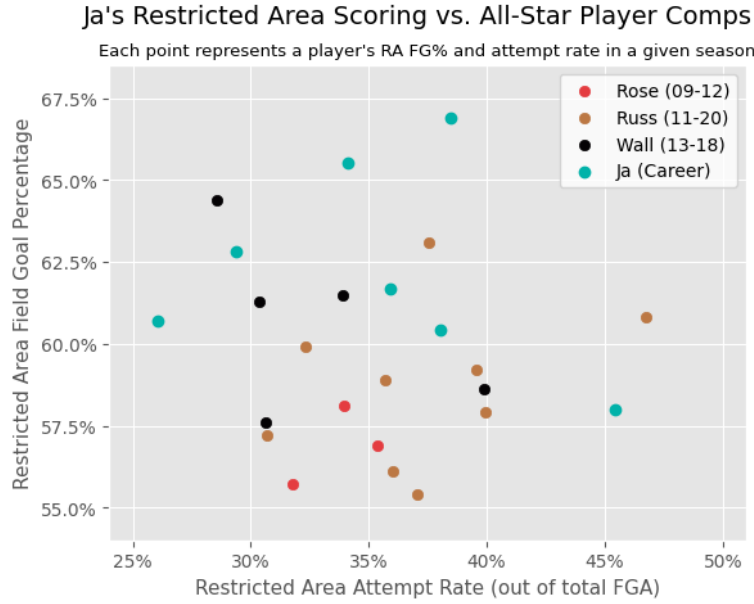


Figure 6: Morant's restricted area scoring compared to his player comps

Test Design

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$$H_o : \theta_C - \theta_{26} = 0$$

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Let θ_{AS} represent a statistic from Morant's two All-Star seasons: 2021-23.

$$H_o : \theta_{AS} - \theta_{26} = 0$$

$$H_a : \theta_{AS} - \theta_{26} > 0$$

NOTE: I do not have access to Morant's restricted area field goal attempts game-by-game. The four tests were conducted on vectors of zeros and ones.

- In the RA Attempt Rate case:
 - Zeros represent field goal attempts from outside the restricted area.
 - Ones represent field goal attempts from within the restricted area.
- In the RA Field Goal Percentage case:
 - Zeroes represent missed RA field goal attempts.
 - Ones represent RA field goal makes.

This is questionable because it treats each field goal attempt independently and doesn't recognize autocorrelation within games. However, I applied this same shabby bootstrap analysis to the previous section's tests as a reference, and the results were extremely similar to the game-by-game approach that I reported. Given that all four confidence intervals are very decisively rejected or accepted in this case, I feel more comfortable reporting the results with this caveat noted.

Test Results

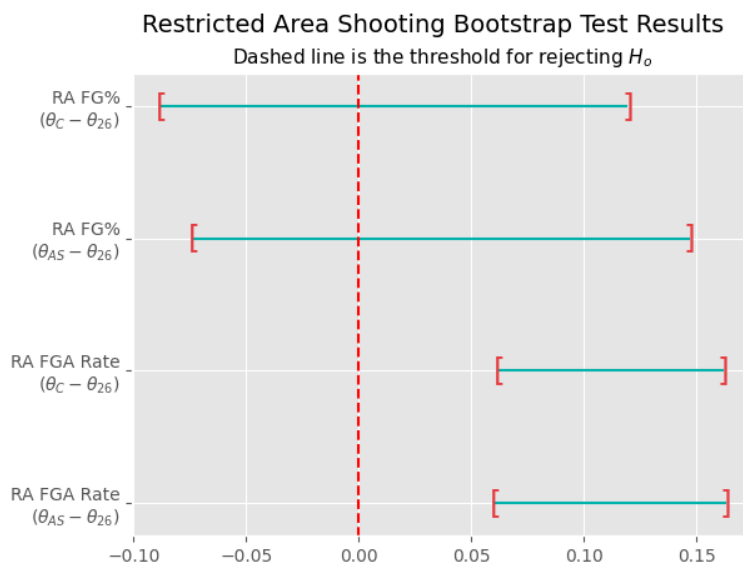


Figure 7: Bootstrap Results for Morant's Restricted Area Shooting

On the bright side, Morant's 2025-26 restricted area field goal percentage remained very similar to his usual career and All-Star levels. However, there is some concern about his attempts. There is statistical weight behind the trend of his RA field goal attempt rate (Figure 5). We've already covered that Morant's 2025-26 efficiency numbers were weighed down by nine extremely poor shooting nights. However, we've already established he has never been a great jumpshooter (Figure 1). If Morant's rim attempts continue to decrease, his overall effectiveness will decrease as well.

Attacking the Paint*

A decrease in Morant's rim attempts might not necessarily mean that he was attacking the basket less often. NBA.com also tracks attempts that are inside the paint, but outside the restricted area. For some more reference, I plotted Morant's paint shooting splits against other All-Star caliber players. Rose, Westbrook, and Wall all had very low attempt rates, making for a less interesting contrast. Instead, I used the shooting stats of more recent slashing All-Star caliber guards of various heights (Figure 3).

Yes, Shai and Luka are closer to seven feet tall than six foot. However, Donovan Mitchell and De'Aaron Fox have comparable stats from floater territory despite being much shorter. Fox doesn't have Morant's nuclear athleticism, but he does have top-notch speed and better touch around the basket. Morant measures up to other shorter slashing guards like Tyrese Maxey and Jamal Murray, but he has a much higher attempt rate than those two, despite being on the lower part of the field goal percentage axis. If Morant is going to attack the rim less and take shots from this territory as often as he does, he needs to improve his proficiency. Especially if defenders continue urging him to shoot jumpshots, they'll be in a better position to defend a paint field goal attempt.

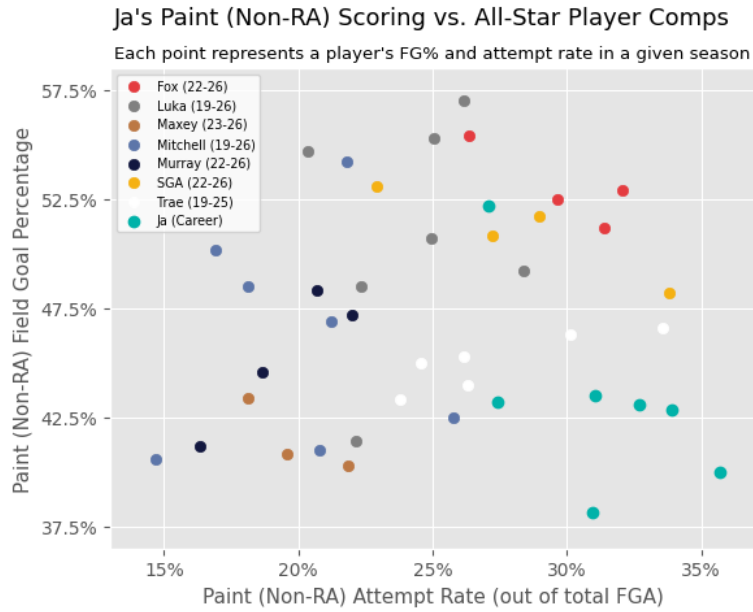


Figure 8: Morant's Paint (Non-RA) Shooting Stats Contrasted to Other All-Stars

Test Results

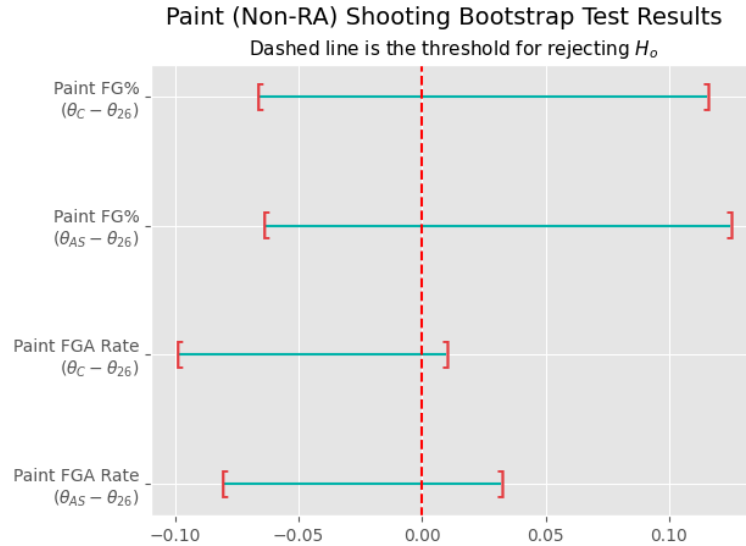


Figure 9: Bootstrap Results for Morant's Paint (Non-RA) Shooting

Unlike the trend his rim attempts experienced, Morant attempted paint (non-restricted-area) field goal attempts at a career high rate. His field goal percentage on those attempts was slightly below his career average (40% vs 42.5%, but the differences weren't significant (Figure 9).

Drawing Fouls

Back to positives, Morant has maintained an extremely high free throw attempt rate FT_r (FTA/FGA) combined with elite efficiency (Figure 10).

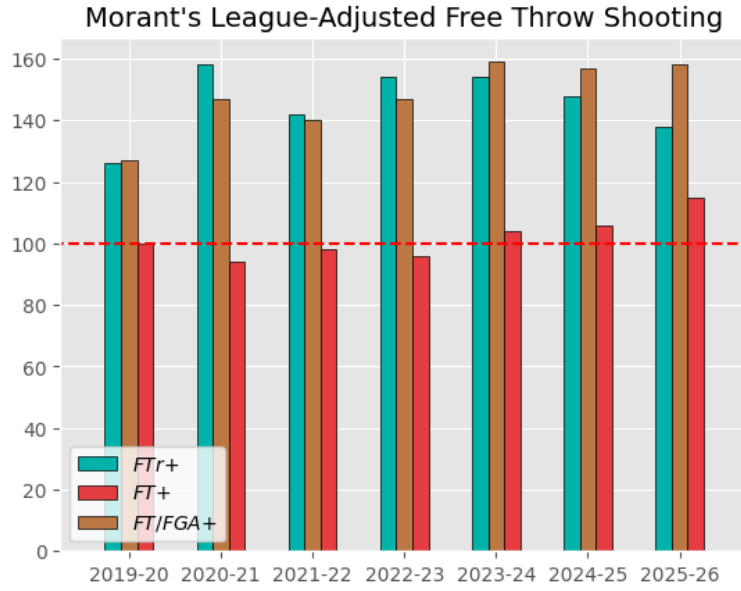


Figure 10: Morant's $FT+$, $FTr+$, and FT/FGA

Despite all concerns about Morant's rim scoring, his free throw attempts have remained constant. That reflects he's still being very aggressive and it will be a huge boon for his efficiency. On top of Morant's consistent free throw attempts, he shot a career high from the free throw line in his limited time on the court in 2025-26 (Figure 10).

Test Results

There was a significant difference in Morant's free throw shooting, positively speaking (Figure 11).

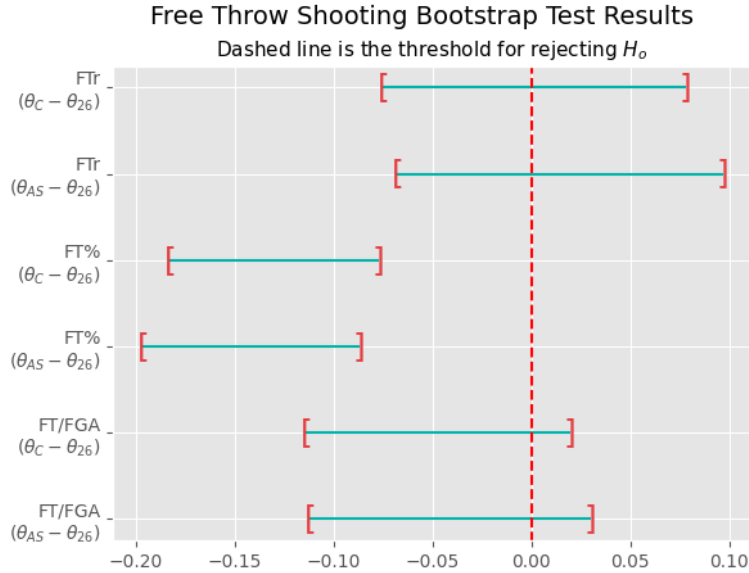


Figure 11: Free Throw Bootstrap Results

Both $FT\%$ intervals easily cleared the threshold for rejecting H_0 . Free throw shooting

was the only shooting efficiency category where Morant's stats didn't take a step back. I already expressed how his efficiency stats from 20 games were weighed down by nine terrible games (4). It's encouraging that his shooting profile remained mostly constant. His rim attempts were significantly down, but his paint attempts were not, nor was his free throw attempt rate. Given that he was attempting more threes and less free throws in those eleven first-half games in 2025-26, that could also be an explanation for the dip in rim field goal attempts.

Injuries

The 2025-26 season was a lost one for Memphis. It was the first full season under Tuomas Iisalo, which Memphis was very excited about, but the team took a significant turn for the worse. It was very similar to the 2023-24 season in terms of calamity:

Season	W-L	# of Different Players	Unique Starting Lineups	Ja Games Missed
2023-24	27-55	33	51	73
2025-26	25-57	33	48	62

Table 6: Tough Seasons for Memphis

The team had problems in addition to Morant's disappointing season. 33 players were the most among all NBA teams in 2026; no other team saw even 30 players suit up for them. As you can guess from the staggering number of unique players, Memphis's core players were ravaged by injury problems:

- Ja Morant
 - 20 games played (Season-ending elbow injury)
- Zach Edey
 - 11 games played (Left ankle injury)
 - FIVE total minutes played alongside Ja Morant
- Jaren Jackson, Jr.
 - 45 games played (Traded to Utah)
- Ty Jerome
 - 15 games played (Calf injury)
 - Signed a 3yr/\$28M contract in the 2025 offseason
- Santi Aldama
 - 43 games played (Season-ending knee surgery)
- Scotty Pippen, Jr.
 - 10 games played
 - Dealt with a toe injury all season
- Brandon Clarke (Rest in Peace)
 - Played just 20 minutes

- Right knee injuries derailed his season
- Kentavious Caldwell-Pope
 - 51 games played (Season-ending finger injury)
 - 31.6 $3P\%$

These eight players comprised 74.4% of the Grizzlies' payroll (including Jackson's \$35M salary) while only playing 25.8% of the team's total minutes. The Grizzlies entered tank mode very soon and that's where all of the ten-day contracts and G-League call-ups came from. The only day one players who had healthy seasons were second-year man Jaylen Wells, standout rookie Cedric Coward, and pleasant surprise Cam Spencer. The instability of the Grizzlies' roster is very likely a contributor to Ja's struggles.

Conclusion

Ja Morant had a nightmare season in 2025-26, but given the small sample size, the team crumbling around him, and the underlying trends in his shot selection, I think there is reason to believe he'll be fine. He attempted fewer shots at the rim, continuing an already existing trend, but he's still shooting well from the paint, the free throw line, and drawing fouls at an elite rate. His last eight games of 2025-26 looked far more like the Ja we're accustomed to seeing, and I believe he's still that same guy.

The transition to Portland marks a new era in Morant's career. It seemed like he needed a change of scenery, but the Blazers' roster situation is cluttered, to say the least:

Point Guards	Shooting Guards
Ja Morant	Shaedon Sharpe
Damian Lillard	Sidy Cissoko
Jrue Holiday	Vít Krejčí
Scot Henderson	Chris Youngblood (2W)
	John Tonje (2W)

Table 7: The Blazers' Backcourt Situation

It will be interesting to see how the Blazers manage their four point guards. None of them are inherently pass-first players, so they are all candidates for off-ball guard minutes. They will likely experiment with different lineups and find the best on-ball guards.

Ja Morant		Damian Lillard (24-25)		Jrue Holiday		Scot Henderson	
$AST\%$	$TOV\%$	$AST\%$	$TOV\%$	$AST\%$	$TOV\%$	$AST\%$	$TOV\%$
45.1%	16.0%	32.1%	16.2%	22.8%	15.9%	29.7%	12.2%

Table 8: The Blazers Backcourt's 2025-26 Passing Stats

References

- [1] The Associated Press, “Grizzlies’ Brandon Clarke (knee) slated to return in 6 to 9 weeks,” *NBA.com*, 11 Nov. 2025, [URL](#).
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- [4] Cole, Damichael, “Ja Morant injury update: Latest on a potential return vs Utah Jazz,” *Commercial Appeal*, 11 Dec. 2025, [URL](#).
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- [6] MacMahon, Tim, “Grizzlies rule Ja Morant’s season over due to left elbow injury,” *ESPN.com*, 24 Mar. 2026, [URL](#).
- [7] “Grizzlies provide new timeline for Zach Edey ankle injury,” *BasketNews*, 14 Jan. 2026, [URL](#).
- [8] “Ty Jerome Injuries,” *FoxSports*, [URL](#).
- [9] “Memphis Grizzlies Team Colors,” [URL](#).
- [10] Statistics taken from *NBA.com*, *Basketball-Reference*, *Cleaning the Glass*, *Dunks and Threes*, *Databallr*, and *HoopsHype*.